THE MADRAS CROCODILE BANK TRUST

The Madras Crocodile Bank Trust and Centre for Herpetology was the brain child of the legendary Romulus Whitaker and a handful of like-minded conservation visionaries, who began work on the facility in 1976. It aimed to save India's dwindling crocodilian population. The mission is to promote the conservation of reptiles and amphibians and their habitats through education, scientific research and capture breeding. The crocodile bank remains a world leader in the field of frontline conservation and the preservation of natural landscapes. The Crocodile Bank currently consists of a large reptile park near Chennai and several field projects located throughout the subcontinent reaching as far as the Nicobar Islands. About half a million people visit the bank every year, making it one of the most popular tourist attractions along the East Coast Road.

Biosphere Reserve (BR):

Biosphere Reserve (BR) is an international designation by UNESCO for representative parts of natural and cultural landscapes extending over large area of terrestrial or coastal/ marine ecosystems or a combination thereof. BRs are designated to deal with the conservation of biodiversity, economic and social development and maintenance of associated cultural values. Biosphere Reserves are thus special environments for both people and nature and are living examples of how human beings and nature can co-exist while respecting each other's needs. The Biosphere Reserve Programme is guided by UNESCO's Man and Biosphere (MAB) programme, as India is a signatory to the landscape approach supported by MAB programme. The scheme called Biosphere Reserve was implemented by the Government of India in 1986. There are 18 Biosphere Reserves in the country.

Arignar Anna Zoological Park, Vandalur

Arignar Anna Zoological Park is spread over an area of 602 hectares. of Reserve Forest at Vandalur, Chennai. It is one of the largest zoo in South East Asia in terms of area. The Zoological Park exhibits different classes of animals – it has around 2500 wild animals of nearly 180 species which includes Mammals, Birds and Reptiles. 34 years since its establishment, the Zoological Park has emerged as a successful ex-situ conservation centre and a captive breeding centre for many endangered species like Royal Bengal Tiger, Lion Tailed Macaque, Nilgiri Langur, Gray Wolf, etc.,

The Zoo has many attractive features like Butterfly Park, Childrens Park, Walk Through Aviary, Lion & Deer Safari, Forest Museum, Interpretation centre, etc., which attracts more than 21 lakh visitors every year. The Zoo has strengthened its protection by means of installing CCTV Cameras for both visitors and animal management under the name of Zoo e-Eye. 24 x 7 Animal Live Streaming was introduced for the benefit of the visitors for the first time in the world. Vandalur Zoo Mobile Application was introduced to provide services to the visitors like facility to book tickets, Zoo navigation, Animal information in text and audio format. Digital payments at ticket counters are also available.

The Zoo school has been involved in education and outreach programmes. One such successful programme is 'Zoo Ambassador' which is been conducted for school children. In the year 2018, more than 400 students were trained and titled as Zoo Ambassadors. The Zoo also has a Rescue Centre which accommodates rescued wild animals and treats them to come out of stress.

Source: Director, Arignar Anna Zoological Park, Vandalur, Chennai

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